Margin

A manuscript on a desk. Content reads like a book; the editor's notes live in the margin.[1]

The page

Everything a person writes or reads: one column of 68 to 72 characters, Literata.

The margin

Numbered notes about the page: problems, hints, and the narrator's trace. Nothing else.

The desk

Navigation and controls the software owns, in Atkinson Hyperlegible, kept quiet.

1 Third iteration
Revised after a survey of twenty writing, narrative, TTRPG, and AI game tools.

Influences

Mechanics borrowed from tools that work, and the looks Margin avoids. Each borrowed idea is used for a specific job; none of the sources' visual styles are copied.

Source	What works there	Use in Margin
Inform 7	Facing pages: writing beside the system's response	Page and margin; the margin carries only notes
Inky	Issue list with jump to line	Numbered notes and a note index in the page header
articy:draft	Nodes holding logic are marked	Graph nodes with rules carry a tick; hover shows the sentence
Twine	Dotted outline for unwritten passages	Stub rooms, stages, and NPCs drawn dotted
Yarn Spinner	Node cards show their first lines	Graph nodes show title and first line of text
Home Assistant	When, And if, Then do; run traces	Rule inserts in three rows; playtest trace in the margin
Apple Shortcuts	Actions summarised as sentences	Collapsed rules read as one sentence with underlined tokens
NovelAI, iA Writer	Marking who wrote which text	Narrator, players, and author edits set apart in the log
Hidden Door	Free text alone causes writer's block	Two or three suggested actions beside the input
LegendKeeper	Inline secret blocks; clean UIs risk a blank page	GM-only text marked in the margin; annotated examples on first run
Quest	Mad Libs style character questions	Character creation as sentences with blanks
Tufte CSS, Gwern	Numbered sidenotes that fall inline on phones	Note numbers; notes drop below their line on narrow screens

Avoided

Card grids Identical rounded cards with soft shadows. Margin uses lists, tables, and inserts on the page.

Default component kits Zinc greys, violet accents, Inter. Margin's tokens and type are its own.

The editorial AI look Cream ground, terracotta accent, italic serif headlines, tracked capitals. Literata is content, never branding.

Chat bubbles The play log is a book page, not a messenger thread.

Node-editor chrome Dotted grids, coloured header bars, minimaps. Graphs are drawn like a drafting plate.

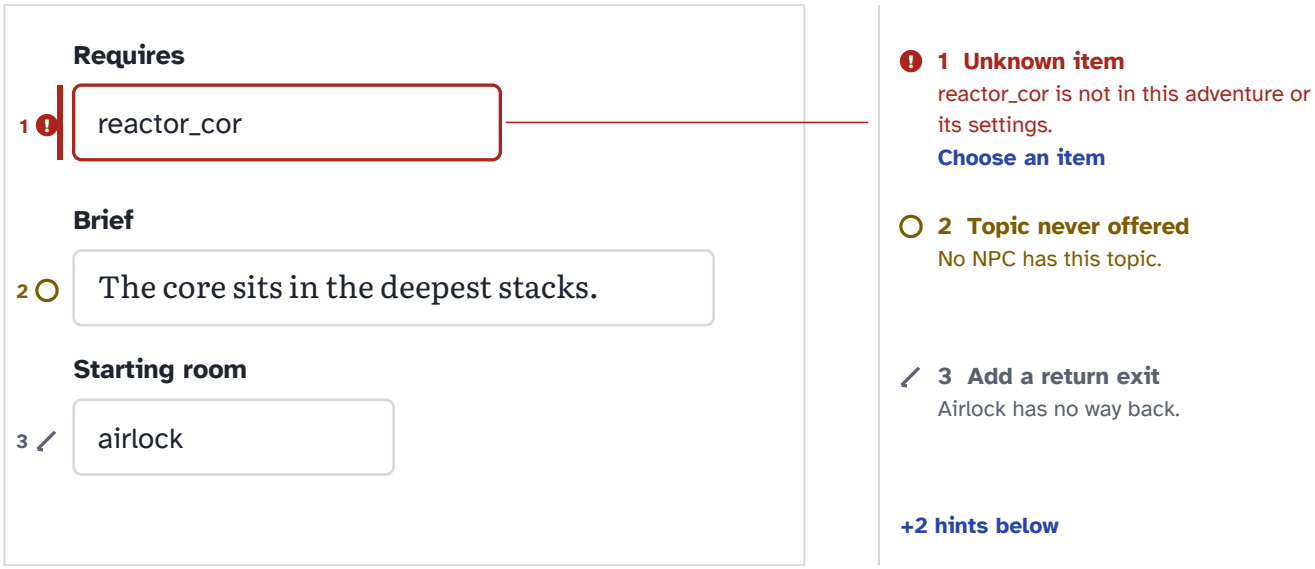
Margin notes

Notes are numbered and typed by shape. The page shows a numbered mark in its gutter; the note sits beside it in the margin. A leader line appears only for the note in focus.

Kinds

●	**Error**	Filled mark. Blocks publishing. The only use of red.
○	**Warning**	Open ring. Publishing allowed: unused flags, unreachable topics.
✎	**Hint**	Pencil stroke. Guidance while filling a form; gone once valid.
■	**Trace**	Numbered square. Playtest and author view only: which rule fired and why.

On the page



Focus	The focused note draws a 0.6 px leader from its line to the margin. Other notes show only the gutter mark.
Numbers	Notes are numbered down the page. The same number appears in the gutter and the note.
Stacking	A note aligns with its line. When notes would overlap, each sits below the previous with 8 px between.
Overflow	Hints beyond the page's visible height collapse into one line, +2 hints below. Errors never collapse.
Resolving	Fixing an error removes its note. Dismissing a warning leaves a faint gutter tick for this draft.
Elsewhere	Notes about other sections collect above the first note, with a link to the record.
Narrow screens	Below 1024 px the note renders under its line, marked with a down arrow and its number.
Assistive tech	Each note is linked to its field with aria-describedby and follows it in reading order. Leaders are decorative.

Controls and states

Every control has the same five states. Focus is always visible: a 2 px Fountain ink ring, 2 px out.

Buttons

	Rest	Hover	Focus	Disabled	Loading
Primary	Publish	Publish	Publish	Publish	Publishing
Secondary	Export	Export	Export	Export	
Quiet	Add trigger	Add trigger	Add trigger	Add trigger	
Danger	Delete	Delete	Delete	Delete	

Loading replaces the label with the action in progress (Publishing) and keeps the width. Danger actions ask for confirmation in a dialog that repeats the object's name.

Fields

Rest

airlock

Focus

airl

Error

reactor_cor

Disabled

quest

Selection controls

- [x] Only once
- [ ] Automatically resume

- ( ) Fighter
- (•) Spy

Menus, dialogs, toasts

Archivist Oyelaran
Rook's contact
Warden Ilse
New NPC

Delete the arc Find the core?

Its 4 triggers and 2 stages are removed from the draft. Published versions are unchanged.

Keep arc | Delete arc

Published 1.2.0

Toasts confirm with the action's own verb, last 5 s, and never carry errors.

Rule inserts

Triggers are typeset on the page between hairlines, not boxed. Collapsed, a rule is one sentence; expanded, it splits into When, If, and Then.

Collapsed

Hear about the core — Only once

When a player asks the Archivist about the core, start Find the core

Escape with the core — Only once

1 When a player enters the Airlock, if core found, end the game: escaped

1 Ending unreachable
No rule moves Find the core to core found.
Show the path

Expanded

Hear about the core

When a moment	a player asks the Archivist about the core	**Change**
If a state	arc Find the core is at inactive	**Change**
Then effects, in order	set arc Find the core to searching	**Change**
Narrate	*The archivist points toward the lift.*	

Add condition **Add effect** — Only once

Triggered by

A condition can depend on which When fired. Authors tick the moments from a list instead of typing an id; deleting a moment flags every rule that referred to it.

- [x] a player asks the Archivist about the core
- [ ] a player reads the terminal log

Copy rules

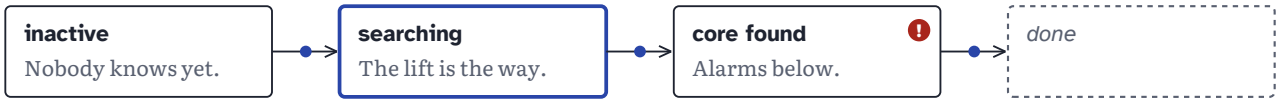
When names a moment: enters, asks, picks up, defeats. If names a state: is at, holds, is set. Mixing them is the commonest authoring mistake, so the pickers offer only the right kind in each row.

Graphs

Arcs and locations are drawn like a drafting plate: a white page, ink hairlines, small index-card nodes with a title and a first line. No grid, header bars, or minimap.

Arc: Find the core

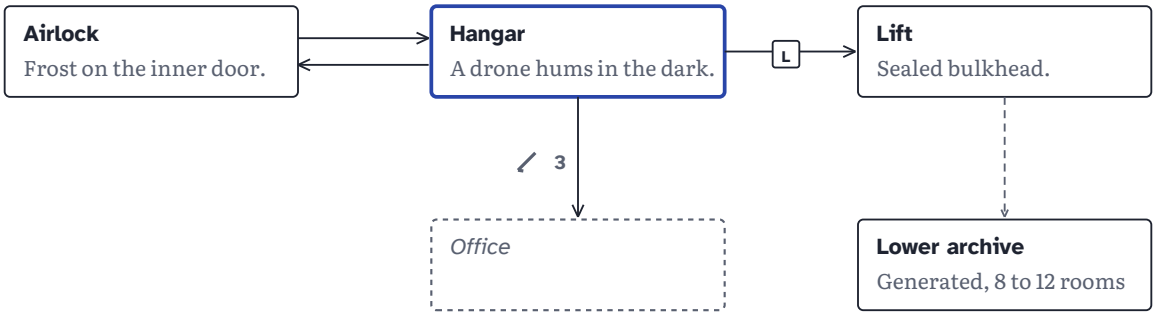
Play from here



Transitions with rules carry a blue tick; hovering shows the rule sentence. The selected stage has a blue outline. Unwritten stages are dotted. A node with a problem shows the note's mark.

Location: Dock

Arrange



Exits are one-way arrows; a pair means a two-way passage. A square on an arrow is a gate. Dashed arrows lead into generated locations. Stub rooms are dotted.

Words

Interface text follows the same rules as the documentation: plain verbs, sentence case, one job per element.

Name actions by what happens

- ● Publish, Invite player, Add trigger, Start instance
- ● Submit, OK, Go, Continue

Keep an action's name through the flow

- ● Publish, then Publishing, then Published version 1.2.0
- ● Publish, then Saving, then Success

Errors say what and how

- ● Unknown item. Choose an item from this adventure or its settings.
- ● Oops, something went wrong

Empty states invite the next step

- ● No characters yet. Create a character to join a game.
- ● Nothing to see here

Use the reader's words

- ● Players, game, session, room
- ● Instance participants, entities, nodes

Label, do not decorate

- ● Starting room
- ● STARTING ROOM, Starting Room:

Two voices

The software speaks in Atkinson Hyperlegible: labels, buttons, notes, and status. The story speaks in Literata: narration, room text, NPC briefs, and anything the author wrote. Player actions in the log are Atkinson, indented under the player's name, so they read as the player's words, not the narrator's.

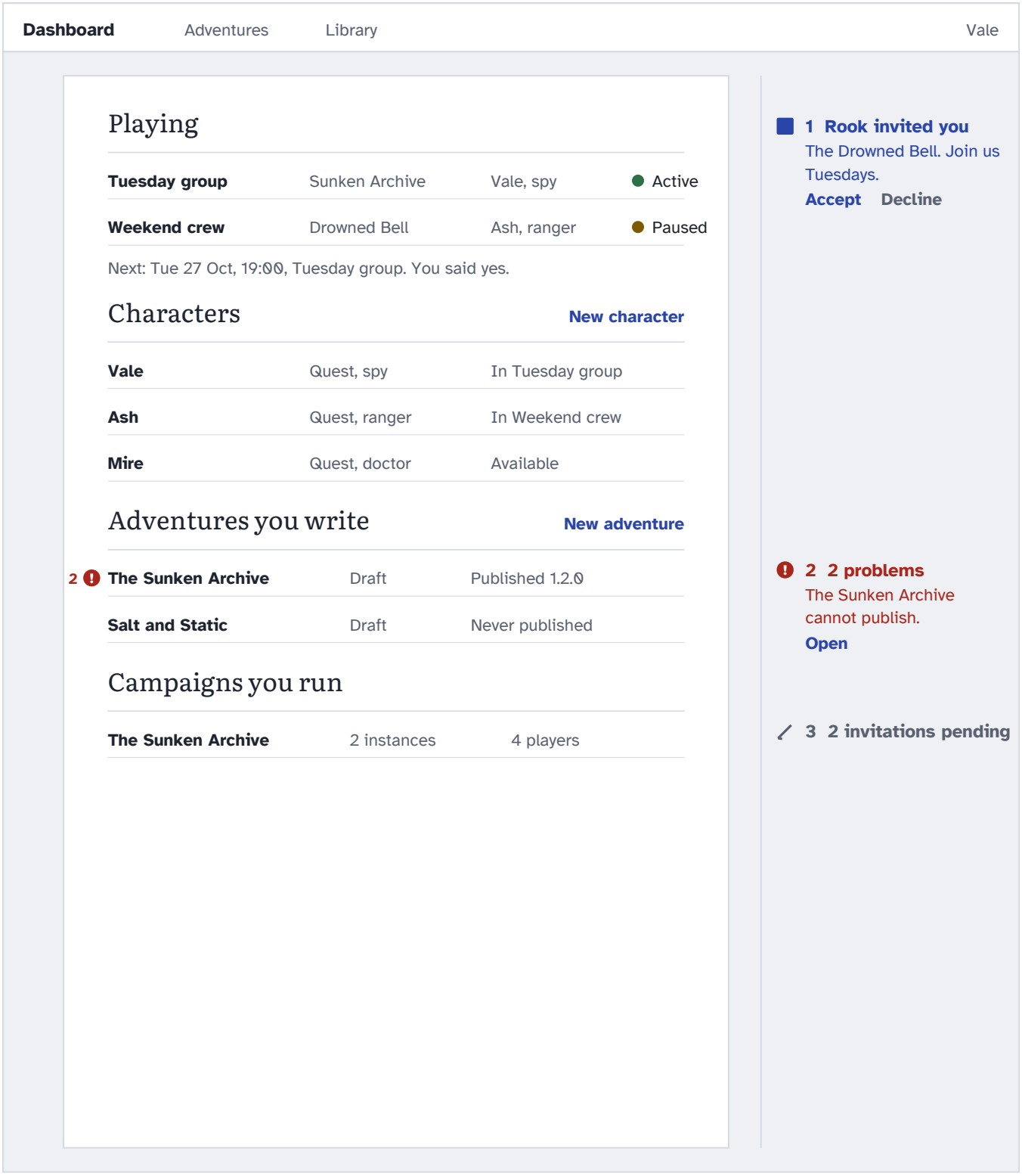
Narrator The panel wakes under Rook's keycard. Somewhere behind the bulkhead, a lift begins to climb.

Player
Rook
check the control panel

Software Rolled 8, tough choice

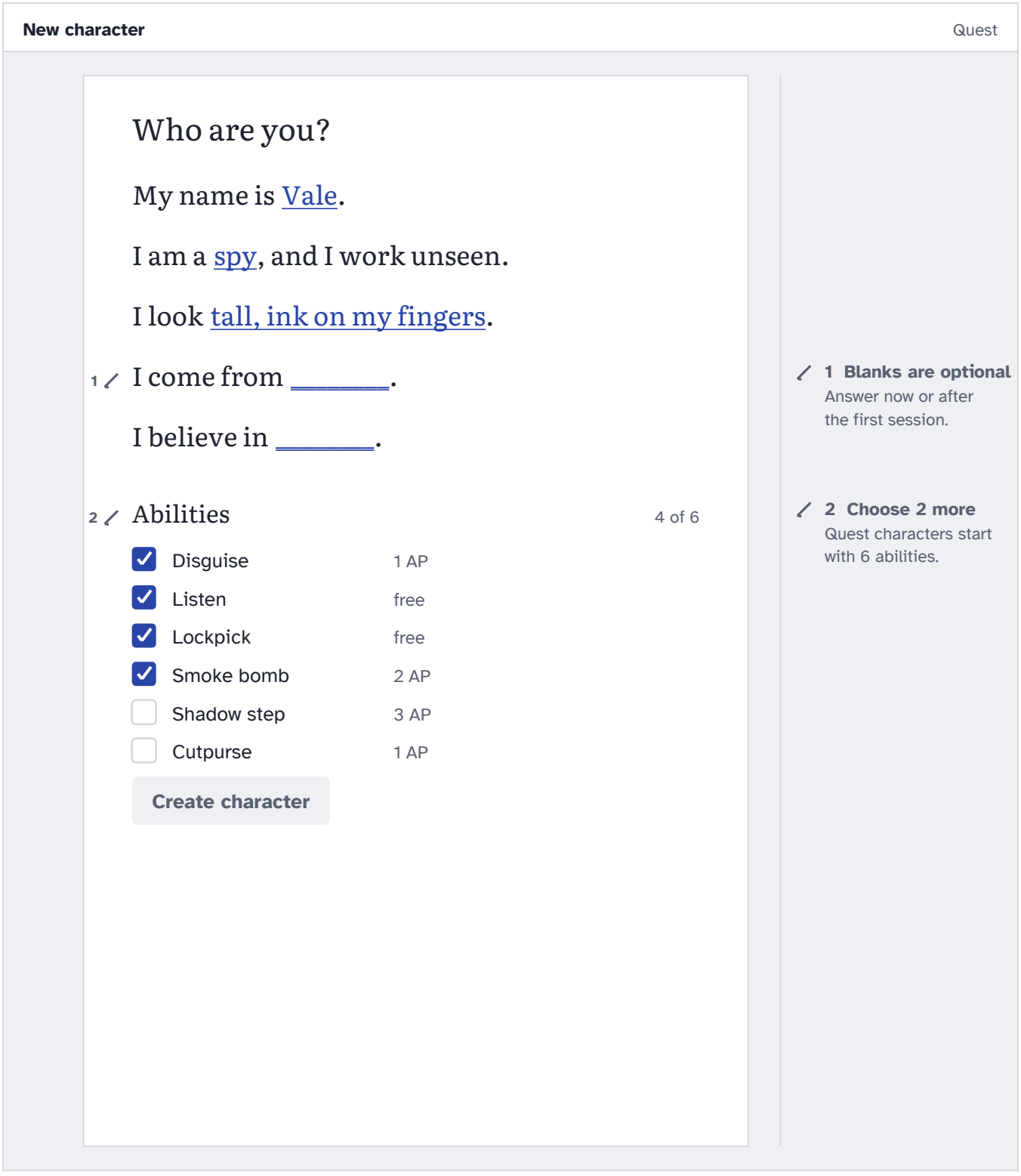
Screen: dashboard

A contents page. Each line is one game, character, or adventure, with its open notes counted.



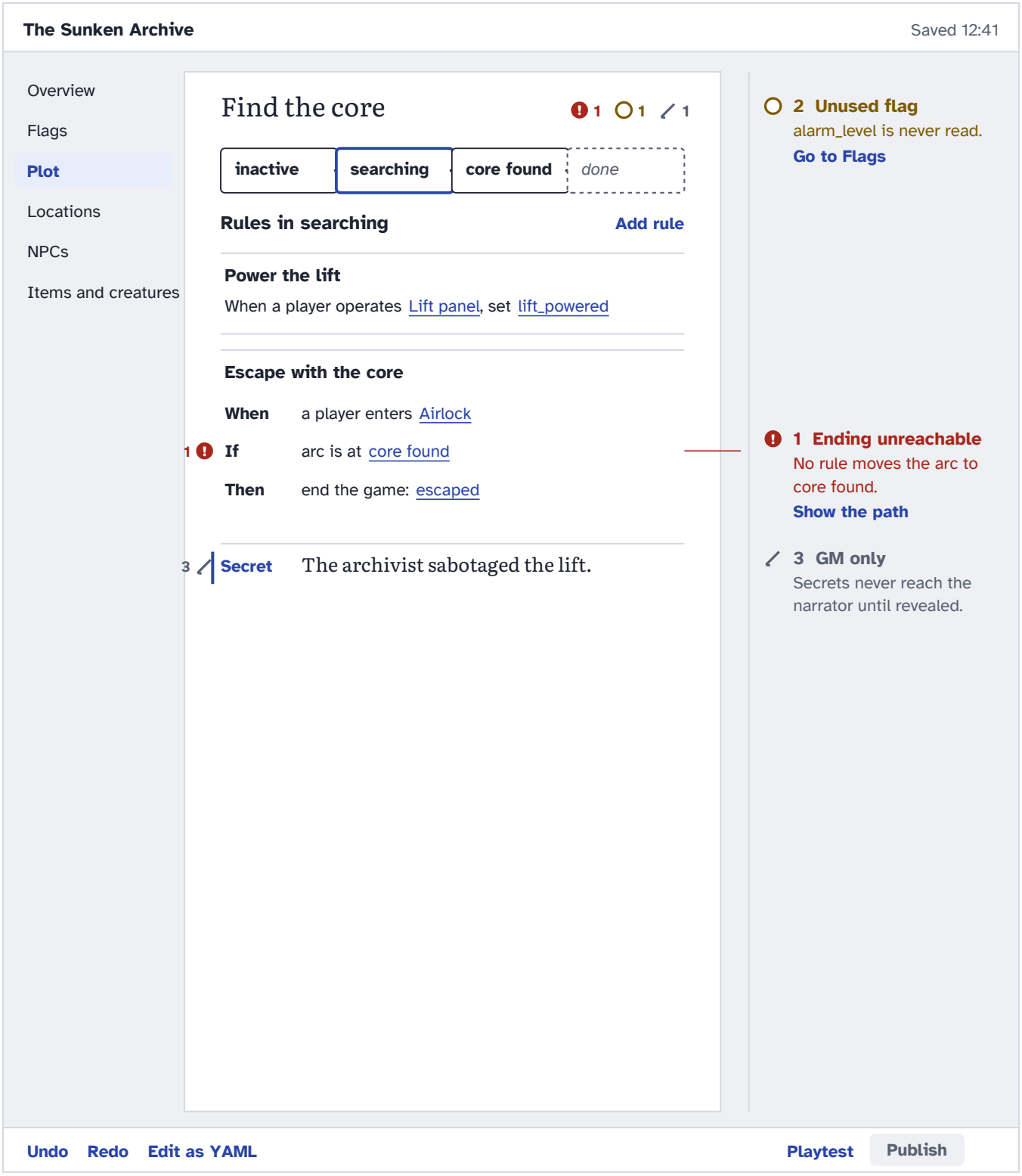
Screen: character creation

Quest characters begin as sentences with blanks, after Quest's own questions. Each blank opens a picker or a short text field.



Screen: adventure editor

Plot section. The arc is drawn on the page; its rules follow as inserts. The note index in the header counts and jumps to notes.



Screen: play, player view

A book page. Narration in Literata; each player's action set in Atkinson, indented under their name. The margin shows turn order and who is typing.

Tuesday group — Round 4, everyone acts

Vale, spy
7/10 HP
8 AP
Wrench, medkit

Hangar
Inner door, west
Lift, sealed

Vale
smash the drone with my wrench

The wrench dents the drone's housing. It staggers, sparks crawling over its arm, and the swing pulls hard at your grip.

Rook
check the control panel

The panel wakes under Rook's keycard. Somewhere behind the bulkhead, a lift begins to climb.

Success, at a cost. Choose a setback:

[Strain yourself: lose 1 HP] [Drop the wrench]

Try: search the hangar · ask Rook about the lift

Choose a setback first

This round

- Vale, choosing a setback
- Rook, declared
- Ash, typing

1:42 left

Screen: play, playtest view

The same page with the narrator's trace in the margin: which rule fired, which condition failed, and what the narrator was told.

Tuesday group — Round 4, everyone acts

Vale, spy
7/10 HP
8 AP
Wrench, medkit

Hangar
Inner door, west
Lift, sealed

Vale
smash the drone with my wrench

1 The wrench dents the drone's housing. It staggers, sparks crawling over its arm, and the swing pulls hard at your grip.

Rook
check the control panel

3 The panel wakes under Rook's keycard. Somewhere behind the bulkhead, a lift begins to climb.

Success, at a cost. Choose a setback:

[Strain yourself: lose 1 HP] [Drop the wrench]

Try: search the hangar · ask Rook about the lift

Choose a setback first

1 **Attack rolled 8**
Tough choice: success at a cost

2 **Drone**
4 to 2 HP

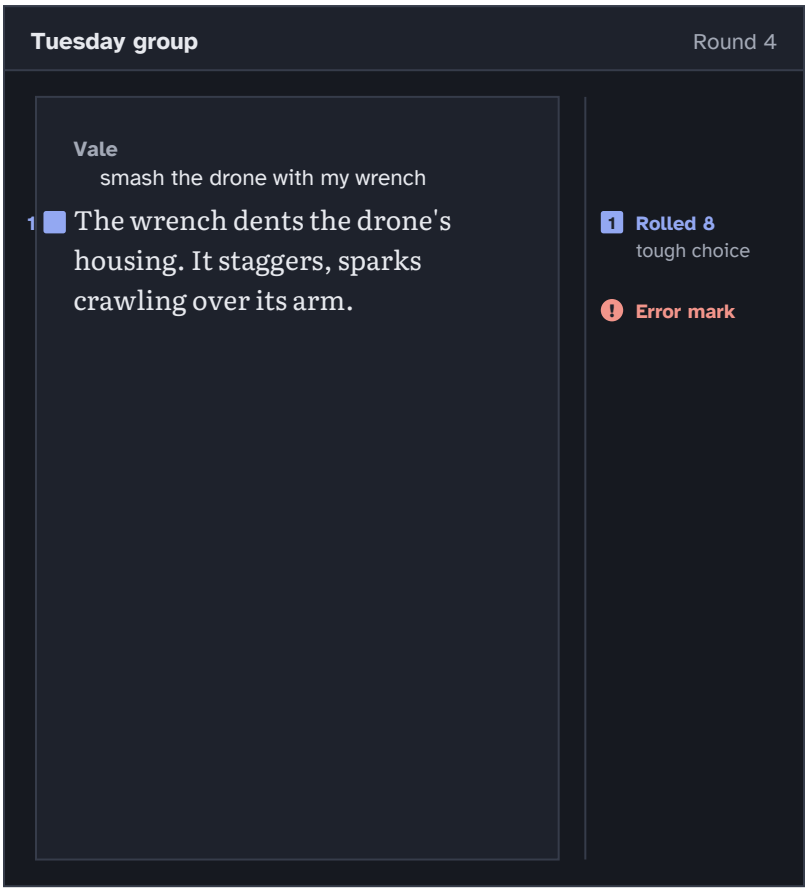
3 **Rule: Power the lift**
fired; lift_powered set

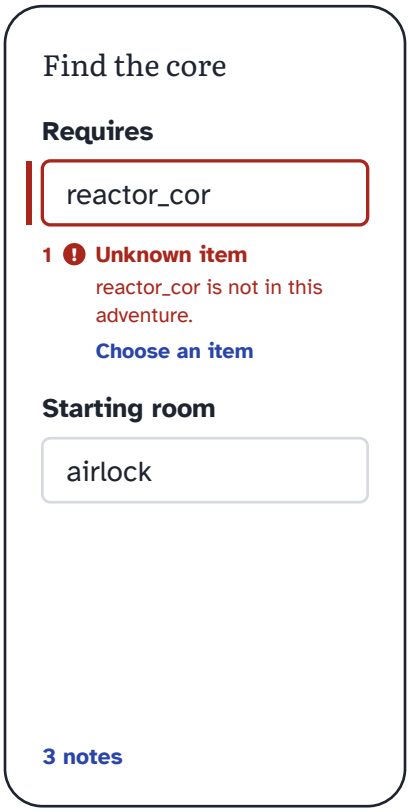
4 **Gate**
Lift opened

What the narrator knows
Room, visible things, flags in play, facts released this turn.

Night and narrow

Dark mode keeps a lighter page on a dark desk, never pure black, with a lighter accent. On phones, margin notes fall under their line.





Dark page	#1E222C on a #161920 desk; text #E7E9EE, 13.1:1.
Dark accent	#93A8F2, 6.9:1 on the page. The light accent fails on dark grounds.
Phone notes	Each note renders under its line with its number and mark; the bar at the bottom counts notes and jumps between them.
Phone play	The trace and turn order move behind a Round button; the log and input fill the screen.

Tokens

Light and dark values for the same names. The theme switches with prefers-color-scheme and a manual setting in Settings.

Token	Light	Dark	Contrast on page, light / dark
page	#FFFFFF	#1E222C	surface
desk	#EEF0F3	#161920	surface
ink	#1E2330	#E7E9EE	15.7:1 / 13.1:1
muted	#596070	#A3A9B6	6.3:1 / 6.7:1
rule	#D5D9E0	#363C4A	surface
accent	#2945A8	#93A8F2	8.4:1 / 6.9:1
accent-soft	#E8EDFB	#27315A	surface
danger	#A8261C	#F2958B	7.1:1 / 7.2:1
danger-soft	#FBECEA	#3A2426	surface
success	#2C7046	#82CB9F	6.0:1 / 8.3:1
warning	#7E5A00	#E5C36F	6.3:1 / 9.4:1

```
@theme {
  --color-page: #FFFFFF;  /* every token as above */
  --font-prose: "Literata", Georgia, serif;
  --font-ui: "Atkinson Hyperlegible", system-ui, sans-serif;
  --radius-control: 3px;  --spacing: 4px;
  --width-page: 34rem;  --width-margin: 14rem;  --width-nav: 12rem;
}
@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
  :root:not([data-theme=light]) { --color-page: #1E222C;  /* … */ }
}
```

Icons

Lucide (ISC license, lucide-react) at 16 px with a 1.5 px stroke, in Ink or Graphite. Icons accompany labels; an icon alone is used only for undo, redo, close, and the menu, each with an accessible name.